

IT IS TIME TO FOCUS

TEXT: Exodus 14:1-4, 8-10, 13-14 (CEV) *“At Etham the LORD said to Moses: ²Tell the people of Israel to turn back and camp across from Pi-Hahiroth (Pee-hah-hi-roth) near Baal-Zephon (Ze-phon), between Migdol and the Red Sea. ³The king will think they were afraid to cross the desert and that they are wandering around, trying to find another way to leave the country. ⁴I will make the king stubborn again, and he will try to catch you. Then I will destroy him and his army. People everywhere will praise me for my victory, and the Egyptians will know that I really am the LORD. The Israelites obeyed the LORD and camped where he told them. 8 The LORD made the king so stubborn that he went after them, even though the Israelites proudly went on their way. ⁹But the king's horses and chariots and soldiers caught up with them while they were camping by the Red Sea near Pi-Hahiroth (Pee-hah-hi-*

roth) and Baal-Zephon (Ze-phon). ¹⁰When the Israelites saw the king coming with his army, they were frightened and begged the LORD for help. ¹³But Moses answered, "Don't be afraid! Be brave, and you will see the LORD save you today. These Egyptians will never bother you again. ¹⁴The LORD will fight for you, and you won't have to do a thing."

INTRO:

(Talk about the fact that Satan doesn't have to get us to commit a mortal sin, all he has to do is distract us – Motorcycle School – There is so much in this world that can distract us – Career – Family – Politics – The world situation Corona Virus – Etc...)

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN THE ARIEL VIEW OF WHERE ISRAEL CAMPED – THE PICTURE IS IN THE POWER POINT OF 10 STRATEGIES FOR DEALING WITH DIFFICULTY – LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL FURTHER

INSTRUCTION)

In this passage of Scripture, the Children of Israel followed God into a cul-de-sac. They found themselves between hostile hills and the edge of a sea, too deep to be forded, and too wide to be crossed. The unmistakable indication of Exodus 14:1-4 is that the Lord took responsibility for leading them into this very dangerous place – AND He did it on purpose!

He gave them specific, step-by-step instructions, leading them down a route to apparent ruin:

“Turn and camp; camp there; there, before the entrapping sea; yes, right there in that impossible place.”

How could Moses and Aaron keep from worrying when:

- The Red Sea was facing them?
- The mountains were beside them?
- The soldiers of Egypt were bearing down on

them with swords drawn?

How can we keep from worrying when hell appears to have emptied out into our living room, and our mother in law is threatening to move in on us? We must keep our focus on Jesus!

The Egyptians were not one bit concerned about a confrontation with the Israelites because these people had spent the last 400 years living as slaves. Not one of them had been trained in the intricacies of warfare, nor did one of them own a weapon!

What the Egyptians did not know is that the Israelites did not need a weapon; they did not need to know how to fight; they had a secret weapon - and His name is Jehovah!

Please understand that God was not being disingenuous to Israel by having them in such a vulnerable spot:

- He was about to deal with Israel's enemies once and for all!
- He was about to allow them to see Him in a way they had never seen Him before!
(Lazarus is dead and I am glad...)
- He was about to provide them with weapons to protect themselves, during the forty plus years of wilderness wandering!

Life can be very, very difficult. The reason life can be so difficult is because God has appointed a destiny for us and there is a real, live enemy, who will do everything in his power to sabotage and keep us back from reaching our ultimate potential.

(TAKE ARIEL VIEW OF THE ISRAELITES AT THE RED SEA DOWN)

The Israelites could have denied the existence of an enemy, but that would not have changed the fact that a hostile king was in hot pursuit of this group of emancipated slaves.

Denial of the enemy never calms his hostilities. Acknowledgement of his existence demands readiness. Charles Spurgeon once said, “*The great tyrant has not forgotten you, and he designs your capture and re-enslavement.*”

When dealing with difficulty, it is imperative that we keep our focus on the Lord.

There is little question with regard to the intentions of our enemy. He is malicious, malignant, and venomous. I assure us, the enemy is not tempting us to allow us to have a good time; he is attempting to drag us down to Hell.

How do we overcome our opponent?

- The blood of Jesus Christ forgives our sins and resolves our guilt!
- The resurrection frees us from the fear of death, and satisfies our need for eternal significance and happiness!
- The presence of the Lord surrounds us!

- The promises of the Bible sustain us!
- The grace of God heals the wounds this world inflicts upon us!
- Our testimony becomes our triumphant shout, and the final nail in the coffin of the enemy!

We can be assured; our enemy will attempt to trap us in our troubles; entangle us in our dilemmas; corner us in an impossible situation; or lure us into temptation.

CONCLUSION:

When the Israelites were trapped at the Red Sea, it would have been very easy for them to get their focus off of what God was about to do and onto what the Egyptians were attempting to do.

When threatened by the devil's schemes, we should focus on the Word. Daniel 11:32 (CEV)
"The king will use deceit to win followers from those who are unfaithful to God, but those who remain faithful will do everything possible to

oppose him.” James 4:7-8 (CEV) ***“Surrender to God! Resist the devil, and he will run from you. 8 Come near to God, and he will come near to you. Clean up your lives, you sinners. Purify your hearts, you people who can’t make up your mind.”*** 1 Peter 5:9 (CEV) ***“But you must resist the devil and stay strong in your faith. You know that all over the world the Lord’s followers are suffering just as you are.”***

We should:

Resist the enemy in the name of Jesus...

Stand our ground against the trespasser...

shake off discouragement, and make the devil take it back...

(END OF SERMON #1)

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Israelites saw the king coming with his army, they were frightened and begged the LORD for help. 13 But Moses answered, " Don't be afraid! Be brave, and you will see the LORD save you today. These Egyptians will never bother you again. ¹⁴The LORD will fight for you, and you won't have to do a thing."

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(Talk about the fact that Satan doesn't have to get us to commit a mortal sin, all he has to do is distract us – Motorcycle School – There is so much in this world that can distract us – Career – Family – Politics – The world situation Corona Virus – Etc...)

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN THE ARIEL VIEW OF WHERE ISRAEL CAMPED – THE PICTURE IS IN THE POWER POINT OF 10 STRATEGIES FOR DEALING WITH DIFFICULTY – LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL I MOVE ON FROM TALKING ABOUT THE CHILDREN OF

ISRAEL AT THE RED SEA)

Every time we resist the slightest temptation, we honor God. Every time we overcome even the smallest problem by trusting and obeying the Lord Jesus, God is glorified in our lives.

The devil came to church one Sunday and started shouting insults at the crowd. Everyone vacated the building except one little old man. The devil shouted to the old man, “*Don’t you know who I am?*” To which the man calmly replied, “*Yes.*” The devil said, “*Are you not afraid of me?*” The man said “*no.*” The devil could not believe his ears and said, “*Why are you not afraid of me?*” The man replied, “*I was married to your sister for fifty-five years!*”

The devil orchestrates all manner of attacks against us, and one of his most effective weapons is distraction. At the Red Sea, the Israelites were distracted by the thunderous noise of Pharaoh’s chariot wheels, but Moses

calmly declared to the Israelites... "*Don't be afraid! Be brave, and you will see the LORD save you today. These Egyptians will never bother you again.* ¹⁴*The LORD will fight for you, and you won't have to do a thing.*"

Pharaoh could:

- Threaten with brute force...
- Protest their emancipation...
- Stir up frightening clouds of chariot dust...
- Terrify with a thousand clanging swords...

Pharaoh was powerless to actually harm the Israelites as long as they remained focused on the Lord. All the Israelites had to do was:

- Remain calm, cool and collected...
- Follow the instructions of Moses...
- Shut out the noise of Pharaoh and his army...
- Focus on a God who can part a Red Sea...

When we become focused on the Lord, the very thing that defeats the enemy brings our victory into view:

- The Rod of Moses pointed the Israelites toward their victory, while pointing the Egyptians to their watery grave...
- The pillar of cloud became darkness to the Egyptians, and a guiding light to the Israelites...
- The wind became a path of deliverance to Israel, and a death trap to the Egyptians...
- The Passover would later become a celebration of emancipation for the Israelites, and the remembrance of a mass funeral to the Egyptians...

As long as we stay focused on the Lord, there is nothing that hell can devise which will be successful against us! Isaiah 54:17 (NKJV)

“No weapon formed against you shall prosper, And every tongue which rises against you in judgment You shall condemn. This is the

heritage of the servants of the LORD, And their righteousness is from Me,” Says the LORD.”

It is time to focus on the Lord.

The reason the Children of Israel were successful against their enemy at the Red Sea is because Moses and Aaron refused to divert their attention from the Lord to Pharaoh. They acknowledged the pursuit of the Egyptians, but decided to focus on what Jehovah was about to do!

Look at the Miracle of the Red Sea crossing:

- The winds blew the sea split!
- The waters congealed into towering walls!
- The Israelites passed through on dry ground!
- Jehovah dried out the Red Sea but did not leave one footprint!

This happened not for the entertainment value of the experience, but to prove to the Israelites and to us, in earth shaking, history-making

fashion that; even when we are most anxious and distressed; God will make a way when there seems to be no way!

Focus does not mean that we will not experience difficulty:

- The Red Sea may roll before us...
- The desert may entrap us...
- The enemy may press in on our heels...
- The past may seem implausible...
- The future may seem impossible...

...but I assure us, God is working in ways we cannot see! This one thing I am absolutely sure of - God will make a way of escape for those who keep their focus on Him! Isaiah 43:19 (CEV) ***"I am creating something new. There it is! Do you see it? I have put roads in deserts, streams in thirsty lands."***

CONCLUSION:

Focus on this:

- There is no sea deeper than the ocean of His

love!

- There is no army stronger than His hosts!
- There is no force greater than His throne of grace!
- There is no enemy that exists who can overcome His direct and indirect work in our lives!

David said in Psalms 23:6 (NKJV) “***Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me All the days of my life.***” (Use three students to illustrate this)

(END OF SERMON #2)